authorities that it was their duty to uphold freedom of expression and not pander to mob demands. It further advised that those who professed themselves hurt by the contents of a book should avoid reading it.[31] I'm glad to hear that Mr Murugan has recently resumed his profession.

Far more alarming than the wrong done to Mr Murugan is the killing of the Kannada scholar M. M. Kalburgi, who was shot dead on his doorstep in his home state of Karnataka on 30 April 2015. Kalburgi was a Brahmin and a Lingayat, a member of a popular devotional sect within Shaivism that rose to prominence in South India in the thirteenth century, its followers distinguishable by the *ishtalinga* necklaces they wear as a symbol of the deity. Although founded as a reforming movement that rejected caste, Brahminical authority and ritual within Hinduism, the Lingayat community has now become a powerful – and, on occasion, intolerant – force within Karnataka State politics.

Some years ago Kalburgi was forced by the Lingayat religious authorities to make a public recantation of some allegedly derogatory references he had made about the founder of the movement, the twelfth-century philosopher and statesman Basava. More recently, in 2014, Kalburgi was alleged to have made critical remarks about idolatry at a seminar in Bangalore, leading to a case being registered against him by the Vishva Hindu Parishad and other religious groups on the grounds that he had outraged their religious feelings under Section 295A of the Indian Penal Code. Kalburgi was given police protection but later asked for it to be removed.

His murder follows the shooting dead in Pune two years ago of Narendra Dabholkar, who was seeking to get a law passed in the Maharashtra Assembly to prevent the exploitation of people through superstition. In February 2015 Dabholkar's rationalist colleague Govind Pansare, a committed left-winger and writer, was similarly murdered in